

HASHKAMA WEEKLY

פרשת מטות-מסעי
כה' תמוז תשפ"ו
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By Reb Gemini חכמה ב-א תאמין?

Consider the following "Torah" thought, generated by Gemini: Did the AI get it right? Do you find it to be accurate? Or did the technology miss the boat?

In Parshas Matos, the Torah introduces the halachos of hagalas keilim right after the war with Midian (Bamidbar 31:23). Elazar HaKohen instructs the Yidden that any utensil used with fire must pass through fire to become tahor. It is not enough to just give a Midianite pot a quick rinse and throw in your Thursday night cholent. The Ramban (Bamidbar 31:23) explains that the koshering process must match the method of absorption; kebol'o kach polto. If a pot absorbed issur through boiling liquid, it needs boiling liquid to expel it. If it absorbed through direct fire, it needs a blowtorch, which incidentally is the exact same level of extreme heat required to get the potato kugel crust exactly how the most demanding baalei batim prefer it at the weekly kiddush. We learn here a profound concept: a kli holds onto its past. It is not just about the surface; the issur is baked into the walls. We cannot just ignore the history of the pot and hope the taam of non-kosher Midianite stew will not ruin the Seudah Shlishis. The absorption requires an equal and opposite reaction to extract the baggage. It is an exhausting process, much like trying to convince the board of directors to fix the AC in the ezras nashim, but absolutely necessary for spiritual survival. We seamlessly transition into Parshas Masei, which meticulously lists the forty-two masa'os the Bnei Yisroel took through the midbar (Bamidbar 33:1-49). The Seforno (Bamidbar 33:1) asks why the Torah needs to list every single stop, including the ones where we complained, rebelled, or simply annoyed Moshe Rabbeinu to no end. He explains that recording these stops highlights the chasdei Hashem, showing how He sustained us even in desolate, terrifying places—which perfectly describes the shul parking lot on a Sunday morning. But the Baal Shem Tov (Degel Machaneh Ephraim, Masei) takes this further, teaching that these forty-two masa'os map out the spiritual journey of every single Jew's life. We all have our own personal Mitzrayim we must leave, and we all have our bitter waters of Marah to drink. Now, observe the connection to the keilim of Midian: just as a pot absorbs the flavors of its environment, we absorb the spiritual residue of our own masa'os. Every stop in our life leaves a taam in our personal keilim. Some stops leave the sweet taste of Torah, while others leave the burnt residue of machlokes and lashon hara. The forty-two journeys are our personal hagalas keilim process. Hashem moves us from station to station, applying the exact right temperature—sometimes boiling, sometimes just a gentle rinse—to purge the spiritual baggage we picked up at the last stop, ensuring our neshamos are ready for Eretz Yisroel. The **practical takeaway** for all of us sitting here today is to finally stop pretending our spiritual pots do not need a good scrubbing. When you catch yourself reacting to your neighbor with the same boiling anger you absorbed at work, remember kebol'o kach polto. You need to actively purge that negativity through limud haTorah or tefillah. Take an inventory of your current masa, recognize the taam you are absorbing from your environment, and do the necessary hagalah before you ruin everyone else's Shabbos.

News & Simchos!

This week's regular Kiddush features pastries, Kokosh cake, and a mercifully short shiur. Endure a few minutes of rigorous Torah analysis to officially justify your massive carbohydrate intake.

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Shabbus Zmanim

Chestnut Ridge, NY

2:30 pm מנחה

6:57/8:12 pm (Early/Late) הדלקה

מנחה - קבלת שבת 7:00 pm

שקיעה 8:30 pm

עלות השחר (16.1/72) 3:47/4:22 am

נץ החמה 5:34 am

שחרית (14 Sergio) 7:00 am

ס"ז קריאת שמע 8:42/9:18 am

ס"ז תפילה 10:08/10:32 am

חצות היום 1:02 pm

מנחה גדולה (גר"א) 1:39 pm

מנחה (14 Sergio) 1:45 pm

מנחה קטנה (גר"א) 5:23 pm

פלג המנחה (גר"א) 6:56 pm

שקיעה 8:30 pm

צה"כ ר' משה (8.5/50) 9:19/9:20 pm

מעריב (52) 9:22 pm

צה"כ (60/72) 9:30/9:42 pm



Next Week's Zmanim

Chestnut Ridge, NY

2:30 pm מנחה

6:54/8:08 pm (Early/Late) הדלקה

שקיעה 8:26 pm

שחרית (14 Sergio) 7:00 am

שקיעה 8:25 pm

מעריב (52) 9:17 pm

Parshah-ly Punny!

Riddle: Why does Parshas Masei conclude the forty years of wandering by meticulously detailing the exact geographic boundaries of Eretz Yisroel?

Answer: Because after dealing with relentless communal complaints throughout the midbar, Moshe Rabbeinu finally needed everyone to know exactly where to draw the line.

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משל ונמשל ב-Al תאמין? By Reb Gemini

Consider the following "Torah" thought, generated by Gemini: Did the AI get it right? Do you find it to be accurate? Or did the technology miss the boat?

Mashal: Imagine a modern-day gvir, let us call him Reb Fishel. He decides he has outgrown the neighborhood and moves to a sprawling estate where the property taxes alone could fund a kollel. He spends millions constructing the ultimate bayis. He installs a walk-in humidior for his cigars, a smart-home system that automatically locks the doors when meshulachim approach, and a reinforced wing exclusively for his wife's Pesach dishes. It is a masterpiece of gashmiyus. However, he has no room for his sefarim shrank, so he shoves his shas into a dark closet next to the boiler. More importantly, he fails to check if there is a decent cheder nearby for his kinderlach. He justifies this by saying he will hire private rabbeim, but he is too busy working to pay the mortgage on the Pesach wing. One Sunday, Reb Fishel accidentally reverses his luxury SUV through his landscaped garden and right into his neighbor's living room. The authorities arrive, the insurance threatens to drop him, and he is a total wreck. He runs to his humidior for comfort, but the cigars cannot calm his anxiety. He runs to the Pesach wing, but the pots offer no eitzah. He desperately needs a chashuve rav for hadrachah and a makom Torah to escape the madness, but he built his existence around his possessions, leaving his neshama completely homeless in a crisis.

Nimshal: This tragedy of misplaced priorities is exactly what transpires in Parshas Matos when the Bnei Gad and Bnei Reuven approach Moshe Rabbeinu. They survey the lands of Jazer and Gilead, see the lush pastures, and immediately think of their massive stock portfolios. They tell Moshe, "Gidros tzon nivneh l'mikneinu po v'arim l'tapeinu" (Bamidbar 32:16). Rashi (Bamidbar 32:16) points out the fatal flaw: they put their cattle before their children. They made the tafel into the ikar and the ikar into the tafel. The Midrash Tanchuma (Matos 7) criticizes this severe lack of daas, noting that they loved their mamon more than their neshamos. They built the climate-controlled humidior of their era and treated chinuch as an afterthought. To correct this warped worldview, Parshas Masei introduces the halachos of the Arei Miklat (Bamidbar 35:11). When a Yid slips up and becomes a rotzeach b'shogeig, he loses everything and goes into galus. But the Torah ensures he is sent to a city of Leiyim, an environment saturated with Torah (Rambam, Hilchos Rotzeach 8:8). Furthermore, the Gemara (Makkos 10a) derives from the word "v'chai" that if a talmid is exiled, his rebbi must go into galus with him! Why? Because for a Yid, life without Torah and a rebbi is simply not chayim. Bnei Gad and Bnei Reuven thought their security lay in their gidros tzon, but the Arei Miklat teach us that the only true sanctuary from the chaos of this velt is the beis medrash and the rebbi.

Practical Takeaway: The practical takeaway for our kehillah is to take a brutally honest inventory of our own gidros tzon versus our arim l'tapeinu. We live in an era where people will spend months agonizing over the exact marble veining for their custom kitchen island, but will spend a grand total of four minutes choosing a yeshiva that will shape their child's entire hashkafah. We must stop treating our gashmiyus like it is the kodesh hakodoshim while treating our ruchniyus like a minor inconvenience. The next time you find yourself in a machlokes with your architect about the dimensions of your walk-in closet, ask yourself if you have put even a fraction of that hishtadlus into your seder in learning or your child's chinuch. Invest in your personal Ir Miklat before the crisis hits. Establish a keviyus in the beis medrash, attach yourself to a chashuve rav who can give you an unvarnished mussar shmues, and make sure your kinderlach see that the sefarim shrank is the most important piece of furniture. Otherwise, you might find yourself with perfectly secure sheep and a beautifully intact Pesach kitchen, but absolutely no chayim.

GOOD SHABBUS!